

BRIEF HISTORY OF THE OLD M.E. CHURCH
ANTWERP, OHIO.

1842-1871

As recalled by JOHN LINCOLN

PIONEER LETTER -- T.W. LINCOLN -1907

SKETCHES OF EARLY ANTWERP - 1844

EARLY HISTORY OF PAULDING

BRIEF HISTORY of the old M. E. CHURCH, and its Members
The Church Forty Years Ago

Methodism in Northwestern Ohio

(This article was printed in the paper Sept. 7, 1899)

As announced last week the Argus promised its readers a brief history of the Antwerp old M. E. church, and we here give it to you as it comes from the old records.

It is the duty of the ministers in charge of the circuit, or station, to keep a correct account or history of his work, and the proceedings, incidents and doings of the station. This never was attended to within the Antwerp society and its limits until in 1871, and therefore has lost much of its past history, dating back to 1860, the year of building the M.E. church in Antwerp. There are many items of interest that we are unable to chronicle.

The Bishop at the last conference in 1871, held at Kenton, Ohio, was pleased to make an appointment for this place, and from 1860 to 1871 there was no particular records kept of the doings of the M. E. society. It was almost impossible to go back and collect past events, but the organization concluded to do the best they could under existing circumstances, and knowing the genius of their old friend, Dr. John Lincoln, who had lived in this country thirty years or more then, decided on having him give a history of early Methodism in Antwerp and vicinity.

He relates it as follows:

"I came to Antwerp in 1842 and not having kept a record of past events, the following embraces only such items as I now recollect:

There were but two appointments at that time in what is now the townships of Carryall and Crane. One was at William Banks, about two miles below Antwerp. The farm is now owned by Thomas J. Banks. The other was the widow Murphy's, now the residence of Daniel Murphy about two miles west of Antwerp, both week day appointments.

The first preacher of whom I have any recollection was Richard Biggs, who travelled what was then known as the old Defiance Mission. This I believe extended as far east as Napoleon, North to Evansport up the Auglaize river about eight miles, south of what is the town of Junction, and up the Maumee river to the Indiana State line, and I believe it also embraced Ayresville, about six miles north of Defiance, preaching from one to three times, nearly every day in the week, and when not preaching, compelled to ride frequently long distances to reach their appointments, and receiving but a very meagre support.

The next preacher was John S. Kalb, who travelled the circuit in 1843-44. Revs. McNabb and Johnson in 1844-45; Rev. W. W. Winster and R.R. Gunn in 1845-46; Rev. Mower in 1846-47; Rev. W.S. Lunt in 1847-48; and also the following conference years 1848-49. Brother Lunt had been a practicing physician whose practice was worth to him between eight and ten hundred dollars per year, and received for his present year's services on the old Defiance mission about three hundred dollars.

The next preachers were Henry Chapman and D.W. Ocker, who travelled the circuit in 1849-50.

They organized the first society in Antwerp, Nov. 1849. It consisted of ten members, namely George H. Ashley and Ann Ashley, his wife; Christian Runion and Nancy, his wife; Robert Murphy and his wife; Daniel Murphy and Hannah, his wife, both young, and myself (John Lincoln) and wife. Robert Murphy was appointed

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leader of the little band and George H. Ashley, Steward. The appointments of William Banks' and at the widow Murphy's were dropped, and the first regular Sabbath preaching every two weeks, was held in Antwerp.

The next preachers were Thomas Parker and Rev. Frownfetter, who travelled the circuit in 1850-51. I was then appointed leader in March 1851, which office I held ten years and until I left Antwerp in 1861. The next two preachers were Benjamin Herbut and Rev. Vertican in 1851-52; the next, Henry Warner and Henry L. Nickerson. Antwerp, this year was attached to Bryan circuit. They travelled the Bryan Circuit in 1853-54. The following year Antwerp was again attached to Defiance circuit. I.S. Albright travelled this circuit in 1854-55.

The conference in the fall of 1855 divided the old Defiance Mission and organized Paulding Mission. This embraced Ayersville, all of Paulding county and Defiance township in Defiance county. The first preacher on Paulding Mission was Joseph Shannon, who travelled it in 1855-56. The next year 1856-57 was Rev. E.G. Longworth and John Driddy. The next was Moses B. Hubbard and Josiah Adams in 1857-58. Josiah Adams and Henry Boyer were appointed for 1858-59.

In 1859 Josiah Adams called the first meeting to take into consideration the building of a meeting house in Antwerp. Two Hundred and fifty dollars were raised at the meeting. A board of Trustees was appointed consisting of W.N. Snook, Joel Bruning, G. H. Ashley, Jonathan D. Phillips, Christ Runion and myself.

Among the numerous objections urged against the measure was that there was not money enough in the country at that time to build a meeting house, for it was as much as every person could do to provide for themselves, the common necessities of life. The season previous, one of the highest freshets that had been known in the country, had destroyed all the crops on the river. A subscription of upwards of \$500 was raised that spring, together with \$90 donated by the Ladies' Sewing society of Antwerp, which enabled the trustees to put the house under contract the same year. A.H. Boland took the contract to enclose the church building for the sum of \$600, furnish all the material for the above amount. The house was finally finished under the administration of Rev. David Bulle in the fall of 1860, and dedicated to service of Almighty God by Rev. Maxwell D. Gaddis of the Cincinnati conference. The lot on which the house stands was donated to the society by the liberality of Mr. W.N. Snook.

The next preachers were D. Bulle, and J.C. Miller in 1859-60-61. The conference in the fall of 1861 divided Antwerp Mission into three distinct circuits -- Ayersville, Junction and Antwerp circuits. The first preacher on Antwerp circuit was John T. Bower, a young man. He travelled this work in 1861-62-63. He received for his first year's support: \$200. The second year he received \$225. He was married the second year to Miss Rachel Winnings of Miami county, Ohio. The next preacher was Rev. E.J. Longworth, who travelled the circuit in 1864, whose salary was \$457.00. The next preacher was Rev. B.L. Rowand, from 1864-66. The next -- Joshua A. Smith from 1866-67. The next minister was I.W. Miller, two years, from 1867-68, to the fall of 1869. The next was I. Wesler Hill in 1869-70. Next was Henry E. Chapman, appointed to this work by his Presiding Elder, Elnathan C. Gavitt in 1870-71.

This brings the record to a close in 1871, (September) up to your time, the services of the present year. I have given you such facts in the history of Methodism in this community, during

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the past thirty years, as they have come to my mind, and observations in the past. A large majority of the preachers were young men, just commencing their ministerial labors, generally only a common English education, yet by close application to their studies and their ministry, some of them rose to the highest positions in the conference. I recollect and call to mind many pleasing incidents connected with the itinerant, and his labors of olden times, as they made their regular visits to this community on horseback, with his usual outfit of a pair of saddle bags containing usually a Bible and hymn book, and such other books as their conference has prescribed for their year's course of study.

In regard to the amount of labor they performed, Thomas Parker informed me when he travelled the old Defiance Mission, that he was enabled to spend from three to four days with his family at Defiance every two weeks, the balance of the time was spent either in preaching or else on horseback in reaching distant appointments, and compelled at the same time to keep up with his prescribed course of study."

--John Lincoln.

Today, Sept. 7, 1899, the old M.E. Church is still used as a house of worship, but a few weeks ago it was removed to a lot on Oswalt street, and within a few short months the old historical ground that it stood on will be graced with a handsome new church. Many old members and citizens recollect the erection of the church in 1860.

Rev. W. S. Philpott, the present minister of the church, has held the Antwerp charge for the past five years, and has done much good in this community. He will leave Antwerp soon to take up his duties in another locality. Rev. Philpott is a splendid citizen and a hard worker in the cause of Christianity. He will be greatly missed by the good citizens of Antwerp and departs from here leaving hundreds of friends.

PIONEER LETTER

T.W.LINCOLN, a former Antwerp resident, now of California,
Writes The Bee Argus an interesting Letter.

Long Beach, California,
March, 16, 1907.

Editor Bee: -- I have been highly gratified at receiving copies of the Bee recently thru the courtesy of cousin Doering and yourself. It comes like the cheering ocean breezes on a hot day. I had not quite forgotten the old time town, but the years have been so full and have gone so rapidly that I have not taken time to think. More than a quarter of a century has passed since I tanned my face toward the setting sun, and here I am on the verge of the continent and on the shore of the Western sea, now looking by faith on as on to the crystal sea beyond. In your columns I find many familiar names that take me back to my boyhood and bring a vivid sense of the old home feeling. Last week I was hurrying to catch the ferry at San Pedro to cross the bay, when I was halted and found Joe Parker a former Hicksville boy, and with him were Mr. & Mrs. John Ainsworth of Hicksville. In talking of the old home, the names of Daniel Murphy and Zeil Burley were mentioned as having died since Mr. Ainsworth had left home, and he remarked that these were among the last of the old pioneers of Carryall township. My interest was awakened and on reaching home I hunted up an old diary which my father began the day of his marriage to my mother. He was then a practicing physician in Antwerp. This was begun in 1844 and ended in 1846 the day of the birth of his oldest son, the writer. In this record I find the names of Daniel Murphy and Zeil Burley. Others mentioned were "Uncle Billy" Banks, "Uncle Ike" Woodcox, Squire Daggett, General Curtis, Wilson, John and Nelson Snook, H.A. Shaffer, Robert Murphy, Dr. Woodcock, Uncle Niram Strout, Ben Wentworth, N. Saylor, Evan Simpson, Jos. Doering, R.V. Spurrier, N. Shirley, G. Platter, S. Swisher, A. Parker, D. Edgar, R.S. Champion and others. All of these were among the first settlers of Carryall Township, and along the Maumee in Indiana. It was then a wilderness and swamp, where only shakes and snakes were its chief characteristics. But there were also squirrels and hickory nuts, wild blackberries and maple sugar, wild turkeys, coons, wild deer, bee trees, and the hundred other luxuries of the olden time not known to the younger generation. I well remember the old log school house on the hill where the Gordon Bros. & Co. block now stands; and the Christmas day when we barred the school master out to make him treat. We then had the old blueback western spelling book, slab seats and quill pens. They were good old days then, though days of hardships and privation. But with the simple wants came peace and contentment.

Some of the sketches in father's diary may be of interest and I will give them in brief:

"Nov. 20, 1844 -- Was the day united in marriage to Harriet Wentworth, living in Harrison township on the Flat Rock or Crooked Creek. Harrison township contains but five families.

Nov. 22 -- Returned to Antwerp to finish my log cabin. It is built of round logs hewed on the inside. Dimensions 16 x 20 feet, one story high, three windows and one door.

Dec. 4 -- Brought Harriet over on horseback and commenced housekeeping.

Dec. 10. -- Thomas Daniel and Obed Wentworth spent the night with us. They are going to the Marie-de-O'Laramie and commence a

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farm. R.S.Champion is the only family there now or between the Maumee and Hicksville. Antwerp contains one store, one tavern, two log cabins, one hewed log house joining the town plat, one frame house near the tavern. Another one fourth of a mile north of town. Most of the town plat is covered with timber."

Passing over several months of the record, on June 1st, is given a description of the old "pike" from the Maumee to Hicksville -- "mostly rails and logs twelve feet long, placed close together and covered with earth thrown out of a ditch on each side six feet wide and two feet deep, the stumps cut down level with the ground. Expense of building the road: \$1.25 a rod. The population of Paulding county is 1304.

June 5 -- Great freshet in Maumee river, the highest ever known. An aged Indian chief in Fort Wayne says that it is 18 inches higher than he had ever seen it. River now supposed to be 20 feet above the common level." From this record I also learn that our one room log cabin with its stick fire place and chimney, was then the meeting house of the town, when the Methodist circuit ride and the Presbyterian Missionary found equal cordial welcome and a home. The record gives the names and sermon sketches of some of the. Gathered there for weekly worship would come Robert and Daniel Murphy, Uncle Billy Banks, Wilson Snook, Geo. Ashley and others with their families, finding comfort and joy in the all sufficient grace. The sermons were doctrined chiefly on "perseverance of the saints" and "free grace", but all Presbyterians and Methodists agreeing on the essentials of the atonement and of divine love for the sinner. Often I find myself longing for the simple life of the old days as I knew them and to get away from the rushing, nerve-racking, soul-blinding and unsympathising time in which we now live. It would be refreshing to see again the "Daggett girls", or reverently to sit under the spell of the prayers of "Mother Fisher" or run over to "Aunt Sally Woodcox" on an errand. They were good days then, but have passed with the passing of the years and the changes that these bring to all.

May I add a word personal? In 1878 I left home for the West. I spent seven years in mission work and where I was married. Then to California where I have preached the word for eighteen years. Having long passed the preacher's dead line and health not the best, I have superannuated and gone into the easy work of a newspaper man. I have a good home in Long Beach, the most delightful and enterprising little city of 20,000 people to be found in America. I am well pensioned for life by the church and Uncle Sam. Two children are left to me here while two are at home with their precious mamma on the other side. Sister Lizzie lives in Los Angeles and sister Jennie is devoting her life to my children.

Though so far from Ohio I do not forget the old home. We have an Ohio Association which meets regularly every month, when we find great pleasure in renewing old memories.

-- T. W. LINCOLN

EARLY HISTORY OF PAULDING AND PAULDING COUNTY

With the view of making it the leading town of the locality and eventually the county seat, George Marsh purchased a block of land at the site and in 1850 laid out the village of Paulding, the survey being made by Ezra J. Smith.

The first postmaster when the postoffice was established was D. Hickerson, the business center being built around the public square. Isaac Richardson built the first frame structure in Paulding which became the Exchange Hotel.

Paulding was incorporated April 12, 1873, and A. H. Sheldon was the first mayor.

Paulding was one of 14 counties formed by the Legislature April 1, 1820, from Northwestern Ohio Indian Lands and for judicial purposes was attached to Williams County which then included Defiance and where was located the county seat.

Paulding County was given its own government in 1839, the county seat was located at New Rochester, a village laid out on the south bank of the Maumee River about one mile north of Cecil.

Two years later the county seat was moved to Charloe, established by Benjamin Hollister especially for the seat of county government.

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New Rochester never had a courthouse and the only term of court there was held over the log store of Gen. H. N. Curtis. In order to procure the county seat for Charloe, Charles Hollister built a brick courthouse, 30 by 40 feet, two stories.

Then in 1852 when Paulding became the county seat a meager courthouse was built. It burned in 1868, another building constructed which was replaced by the present courthouse in 1888.

Paulding County is named for John Paulding, one of the captors of Major Andre, War of the Revolution.